

Michael Lopez

Data Strategist · Civic Tech & Social Impact

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Data strategist and operations leader. Six years building the Child Poverty Action Lab's data function from the ground up: the team, the Databricks platform, and the tools that turn public and administrative data into decisions across housing, public safety, maternal health, and benefits delivery.

■ EXPERIENCE

Child Poverty Action Lab DALLAS, TX · 2020 – PRESENT

- **Director, Data Operations** Jan 2026 – Present
 - Lead CPAL's data platform migration to Databricks (Unity Catalog, Workflows, Lakebase + Lakehouse on AWS, Git-tracked orchestration), systematizing 35–40 pipelines from file-based storage onto unified cloud infrastructure
 - Manage a 6-person external data engineering team via vendor partnership executing the internal data roadmap, alongside one full-time data engineer reporting directly to me
 - Built AI-enabled team workflows (Claude Code with custom skills and agents, prompt caching with the Anthropic API), accelerating how we develop pipelines, write documentation, review code, and communicate with stakeholders
 - Develop internal tools that let non-data staff act on data without analyst intervention, including a parcel-level outreach tool with 20 active field-team users
 - Maintain the eviction data workstream (~48,000 Dallas filings a year across four North Texas counties; daily feed to 12+ partners including the Dallas Eviction Advocacy Center, the Princeton Eviction Lab, and Dallas Health & Human Services)
- **Director, Data** May 2023 – Dec 2025
 - Built CPAL's data function from the ground up; led hiring for the org's first data engineer and prior analyst roles
 - Led the data org through the CDO transition (Dec 2024 to Dec 2025): set department roadmap, hiring, vendor strategy, and budget, reporting directly to the CTO
 - Oversaw a 30+ app R Shiny suite informing decisions across housing, public safety, maternal health, benefits delivery, and criminal justice
 - Evaluated and selected the enterprise tooling stack: Databricks (chosen over Snowflake / dbt-Cloud after a capacity assessment), Claude Enterprise org-wide, vendor data feeds (MySidewalk, DataAxe)
 - Built project-management infrastructure in Notion now adopted across multiple CPAL departments
- **Manager, Data** May 2022 – May 2023
 - Led development of R Shiny applications, shifting the organization toward interactive data products
 - Contributed to northtexasevictions.org, a public-facing eviction data transparency tool
 - Mentored analytics interns; one was subsequently hired as a full-time analyst
 - Established data collection and sharing procedures that became organizational standards
- **Associate, Data** Jun 2020 – Apr 2022
 - Created the initial eviction data pipeline in R, laying the groundwork for the system now serving four counties
 - Developed dashboards and reports in R, QGIS, Tableau, and ArcGIS for internal teams and community partners
 - Automated routine data processes, establishing repeatable frameworks used across the organization

■ EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Research Project Assistant, UT Southwestern Medical Center

Dec 2019 – May 2020

Conducted participant interviews and assessments, analyzed data, and produced reports for biomedical research projects.

Health & Social Policy Intern, Children at Risk

Jun 2019 – Aug 2019

Led policy research on early childhood development and developed policy briefs for senior leadership and state stakeholders.

Research Coordinator, University of Texas at Dallas

Aug 2016 – Dec 2018

Managed the Developmental Neurolinguistics Lab; recruited, trained, and supervised 10–15 research assistants each semester and 300+ participants.

Research Assistant, Florida International University

May 2013 – May 2015

Assessed pre-K children's spatial and verbal abilities; trained assistants and recruited participants across Miami-Dade County schools.

SKILLS

Analysis & Languages

R (tidyverse, sf, Shiny)SQLPythonTypeScript

Visualization & Geospatial

R ShinyTableauHighchartsMapbox GLSpatial SQLQGISArcGIS

Data Platform

Databricks (Lakehouse + Unity Catalog)PostgreSQL / NeonDuckDBPolarsPostGISCKAN

AI Workflows

Claude Code (custom skills & agents)Anthropic APISGoogle Cloud Vision (OCR)

Orchestration & Infra

TerraformGitHub ActionsDockerAWSVercelPrefectStructured logging

Domains

Housing & EvictionPublic SafetyMaternal HealthBenefits DeliveryCommunity Development

EDUCATION

Master of Public Policy, University of Texas at Dallas

2021

B.A., Psychology & Anthropology, Florida International University

2015

- SELECTED PROJECTS

Dallas County Eviction Data.

Daily eviction-filing feed reaching 12+ legal-aid and outreach partners; ~48,000 Dallas filings a year turned into tenant outreach.

DigiLab digilab.cards.

Community-sourced tournament data platform for the global Digimon TCG scene; 5,000+ tournaments logged in six months, with regional meta analysis players use to prep.

Parcel Block Walking Tool.

Field-outreach tool flagging homes likely missing a homestead exemption; ~20 active field-team users across outreach partners.

North Texas Evictions northtexasevictions.org.

Public-facing eviction data transparency dashboard for Dallas County.

- SELECTED MEDIA

The Lab Report:

Data visualizations for Dallas homeless-enforcement and patrol-staffing analyses (2026)

D Magazine:

“The Lawyer Who Landlords Don’t Want to See in Court” (2024)

KERA News:

“Eviction less likely for Dallas County tenants who get a lawyer” (2024)